

YES, I DO... AGAIN.

A Novel

SABINO PEREIRA

Copyright © 2026 Sabino Pereira

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously.

CHAPTER ONE — THIRTY DAYS

Tomás found the envelope on the kitchen table between Martim's open lunchbox and a bowl containing three oranges nobody seemed inclined to eat. It was plain white, with no warning printed across the front, but he recognized the narrow blue mark of the National Office of Relational Continuity before he read the return address.

Leonor stood at the counter in the gray hospital scrubs she wore for early shifts. She had already made coffee. His cup waited beside the stove, black and without sugar, as it had on thousands of mornings before this one.

"It came twenty minutes ago," she said.

Tomás turned the envelope over. Both their names appeared on the front, although his was printed first. He wondered whether Leonor had noticed and immediately disliked himself for wondering. "You didn't open it?"

"It belongs to both of us."

That was a reasonable answer. Their life contained a great many reasonable answers.

Martim ran into the kitchen with one shoelace undone and a folded sheet of paper in his hand. At eight, he still moved as though every room had been waiting impatiently for him to enter it. "I finished the family drawing."

He spread it over the envelope. Two houses stood on opposite sides of a blue river. A bridge connected them, and three figures occupied the center, their hands too large for their bodies.

"Why are there two houses?" Leonor asked.

"The teacher said we could draw any kind of family." Martim pointed to the figure with black hair. "That's Dad. You're the one with the red shirt. I made myself taller than last time."

Tomás looked at the bridge. "And why are we in the middle?"

Martim shrugged. "Because bridges are where people meet."

Leonor checked the time and told him to find his other sneaker. He ran away, leaving the drawing over the letter as if the arrangement meant nothing. Tomás slid the page aside and opened the envelope with his thumb.

The notice was shorter than he expected. Their ten-year Identity Review would take place in thirty days. Attendance was mandatory. Beneath the appointment details, five possible outcomes were listed: Renew, Renegotiate, Family Unit, Structured Separation, and End.

Tomás read the third option again. "Family Unit wasn't there at five years."

"We didn't have enough history for it."

"Do you know what it means?"

Leonor poured the remaining coffee down the sink. "Legally or actually?"

"Both."

"Legally, we remain parents, co-owners, and household partners. The romantic relationship ends." She rinsed her cup and placed it upside down on the drying rack. "Actually, I imagine it means admitting what some people already are."

Tomás looked at her. "Are you saying that's us?"

"I'm saying Martim will miss the bus."

They left the apartment seven minutes later, carrying the objects that had come to define their mornings: backpacks, keys, phones, a reusable bottle, Leonor's badge, Tomás's laptop. The notice stayed on the table beneath the drawing of the bridge.

After dropping Martim at school, Tomás remained parked by the curb. Children passed the windshield in bright jackets, leaning forward beneath the weight of their bags. Leonor had one hand on the door handle when he asked whether they were going to renew.

She closed the door again. "Is that what you want to ask?"

"It is the question."

"No. It's the answer you expect."

He felt irritation before fear, which was how fear usually reached him. "We're not unhappy."

"I know."

"There's no one else."

The pause that followed was brief enough to deny and long enough to remember.

Tomás turned toward her. "Is there?"

"No." Leonor looked through the windshield. "Not in the way you mean."

He waited, but she opened the door. Before stepping out, she said, "I don't know whether I want to leave you. I don't know whether I want to keep being us in exactly this way. Those are different things."

At work, Tomás read the definition of Family Unit three times. The system recommended it for relationships with high structural functionality and low affective reciprocity. He disliked the phrase because it sounded clinical and because it sounded accurate.

He opened his messages to Leonor and typed an invitation to dinner. He deleted it, tried again, and deleted that version too. What he finally sent was a reminder that Martim finished school at four.

Leonor replied a minute later.

I know.

Tomás set the phone facedown. On his monitor, the official countdown had already begun.

CHAPTER TWO — THE CAMPAIGN EFFECT

Miguel wore an apron to dinner, which was the first sign that something was wrong.

He greeted Tomás with a wooden spoon in one hand and announced that the risotto needed another six minutes. Until recently, Miguel had regarded cooking as an activity performed by restaurants, mothers, and people with suspicious amounts of free time.

“How long until your review?” Tomás asked.

“Forty-three days,” Sara called from the dining room.

Miguel pointed the spoon at her. “Growth can happen at any time.”

“Apparently it happens most efficiently under government supervision.”

The campaign effect had become common enough to acquire both a clinical name and a market around it. In the months before renewal, distracted partners became attentive, household work redistributed itself miraculously, and restaurants sold packages promising to “recover relational intention.” Miguel’s place settings came from one of them: two slate-gray cards printed with conversation prompts, a candle advertised as clinically calming, and a sealed envelope marked *Open Only If Dinner Becomes Defensive*. Sara had placed the envelope beside the salt. The behavior might be sincere. That was what made it difficult. Fear could produce a performance, but it could also wake a person who had been asleep inside their own life.

Two other couples joined them. Beatriz and Daniel had been together for eight months and still touched each other without noticing. Daniel rested a hand on the back of her chair whenever he passed. Beatriz corrected his stories and he seemed delighted by the corrections. Their ease did not look permanent, but it looked real.

Leonor watched them over the rim of her wineglass. She did not want Daniel, nor the relationship they had. She wanted the version of herself who had once laughed before calculating whether laughter would interrupt anyone.

During dinner, Miguel asked Beatriz what she expected to choose at the two-year review.

“Renew,” she said. “Unless he becomes unbearable.”

“I’ve scheduled that for year three,” Daniel replied.

Sara smiled without looking at Miguel. “That’s considerate.”

Tomás felt the tension cross the table and settle among the plates. Miguel served Sara first and asked whether she needed more wine. Each gesture was impeccable. Each arrived forty-three days before judgment.

Later, Leonor found Sara in the kitchen opening another bottle. “Is he different when you’re alone?”

Sara considered the question. “He listens. He cooks. He booked therapy without being asked.”

“That sounds good.”

“It is exactly what I wanted.” Sara drove the corkscrew into the cork. “I just don’t know whether he changed or whether he wants to be renewed.”

“Couldn’t it be both?”

“That’s what he says.” The cork came free. “If he becomes the man I needed because he’s afraid of losing me, does the reason make the change false?”

Leonor had no answer. She thought of the coffee Tomás made every morning, the insurance renewals he remembered, the way he checked Martim's backpack and kept spare fever medicine in the car. His love had not disappeared. It had become indistinguishable from administration.

Back at the table, Daniel was showing photographs from a weekend by the coast. In one, Beatriz ran barefoot near the water, her hair blown across her face.

"That's my favorite," Daniel said.

"I look ridiculous."

"You look happy."

Leonor lowered her gaze. Her phone lit beneath the table.

Vasco: Surviving the couples' dinner?

She smiled before she could stop herself.

Tomás noticed. "Who is it?"

"Work."

"Work is funny now?"

She showed him the name without opening the message. "Vasco."

Tomás nodded and returned to his plate. The movement was calm, but Leonor knew him well enough to recognize filing. He stored discomfort until he had found a practical use for it.

In the car, with Martim asleep behind them, Leonor said the new couple seemed happy.

"They've been together eight months," Tomás replied.

"That doesn't make the happiness imaginary."

"I didn't say it did. I said the novelty will end."

"And then what?"

"Then real life starts."

She looked at him. "Is this real life?"

"Of course."

"Then when are we allowed to be happy in it?"

Tomás tightened his hands around the steering wheel. "I'm here, Leonor."

"You always say that as if presence were the final argument."

"Sometimes staying is the argument."

"And sometimes it's just the easiest option."

The rest of the drive passed without speech. When they reached home, Tomás carried Martim upstairs. Leonor followed with the child's jacket and shoes. Their coordination was effortless. Anyone watching would have called them a good team.

That night, Vasco sent another message.

Sometimes surviving isn't the same as wanting to continue.

Leonor did not answer, but she did not delete it.

CHAPTER THREE — TWELVE DAYS TOO LATE

On Saturday, Tomás made pancakes. The smell reached the hallway before Leonor entered the kitchen and found him at the stove with flour on his sleeve. Martim sat at the table eating strawberries from the bowl meant for all three of them.

“What’s happening?” she asked.

Tomás turned a pancake. “Breakfast.”

“You don’t make pancakes.”

“That is demonstrably untrue.”

Martim swallowed a strawberry. “Dad is improving.”

Tomás looked at him. “Thank you for making it sound ominous.”

Leonor saw the cut fruit, the warmed plates, and the small jug of orange juice. The effort should have pleased her. Instead, the countdown appeared in her mind with bureaucratic clarity. “There are twelve days left.”

Tomás set down the spatula. “Am I prohibited from making breakfast during the final two weeks?”

“I didn’t say that.”

“You said the number.”

Martim looked between them. “Can I have another pancake before this becomes an argument?”

Tomás served him one. Leonor sat, ashamed of her suspicion and angry that suspicion had become reasonable. The pancake was good. That made everything worse.

Later, while Martim rode his bicycle through the park, Tomás invited Leonor to dinner. He had already arranged for his mother to take Martim overnight.

“You planned it yesterday?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“After the message from Vasco.”

“This isn’t about him.”

“Then why now?”

Tomás looked toward their son, who was making a wide, uncertain turn near the fountain. “Because now I understand there is something to lose.”

The honesty disarmed her. She had expected denial, not fear.

“I don’t know how to receive anything from you without wondering whether it’s campaign behavior,” she said.

“I don’t know how to try without arriving late.”

For once, neither defended themselves. They watched Martim wobble, recover his balance, and continue around the path.

The restaurant Tomás chose was where they had eaten after registering their relationship ten years earlier. The room had been renovated, but the windows still faced the same narrow street. Leonor remembered the cheap wine they could barely afford and the extravagant certainty with which they had discussed houses, children, and cities they would visit.

“You chose this on purpose,” she said after they sat.

“Yes.”

She waited for the practical explanation. None came.

Over dinner they spoke about the review, at first with care and then with the fatigue of people who had been careful too long. Leonor said she wanted curiosity, desire, and the feeling that something still happened between them beyond the management of a household.

"I see you," Tomás said.

"You know me. That isn't always the same thing."

"How can knowing you count against me?"

"Because sometimes you stop looking when you think you already know what you'll find."

He tore a piece of bread and left it untouched. "Does Vasco look?"

Leonor considered lying. "Yes."

"Are you in love with him?"

"No."

"Do you want to be?"

"I like who I am when he talks to me."

Tomás sat back. Around them, silverware touched plates and a waiter recited desserts to another table. Leonor wished the restaurant would become quiet enough to acknowledge what she had said.

"Who are you with me?" he asked.

"Tired."

The word hurt him visibly. She reached across the table, but he did not take her hand.

"I'm not tired of you."

"You're tired of yourself when you're with me. I'm not sure that's better."

Her phone vibrated. Vasco's name appeared on the screen. Leonor turned it facedown.

Tomás laughed once, without humor. "Perfect timing."

"I'm not answering."

"You already answered him somewhere."

At home, the argument continued in the kitchen. Years of reasonable decisions became evidence. Leonor spoke of the London exchange she had declined four years earlier. Tomás insisted he had never asked her to stay.

"You said we would try if I thought I could make it work," she reminded him. "You made the risk mine."

"I was telling you the truth. We had a child, a mortgage, and two jobs in Lisbon."

"I wanted you to say I was worth rearranging things for."

Tomás stared at her. "And I wanted you to tell me what you wanted instead of giving me an exam I didn't know I was taking."

The accusation was accurate enough to silence her.

He turned away, then said he too had given something up.

Leonor followed him. "What?"

"It doesn't matter."

"You cannot introduce a hidden sacrifice in the middle of an argument and decide it doesn't matter."

Tomás gripped the edge of the counter. Three years earlier, he told her, an international firm had offered him a partnership in Dubai. He had declined without mentioning it.

Leonor's first feeling was not gratitude. "You decided for me."

"I decided not to destabilize the family."

"That is what deciding for me sounds like when you say it politely."

They looked at each other across the kitchen, each holding a sacrifice the other had failed to recognize. Leonor began to understand that resentment did not require exploitation. Sometimes it grew from gifts presented anonymously and gratitude expected telepathically.

“How did we spend years choosing each other,” she asked, “and both feel as if we were doing it alone?”

Tomás moved toward her, stopped, and looked uncertain whether touch was still permitted. She noticed the hesitation. It hurt more than refusal.

That night she slept on the sofa. At one twenty-three, Vasco asked if she was awake. She answered yes. In the bedroom, Tomás opened the official simulator and selected Structured Separation.

For forty-four minutes, Leonor and Vasco spoke about nothing they were willing to call important. Tomás studied a future of alternate weekends, divided holidays, and two homes for Martim. In the morning, both would tell themselves they had not crossed a line.

Perhaps they were right. By breakfast, however, Leonor had hidden her phone beneath a folded newspaper, and Tomás had cleared the simulator history from his browser.

CHAPTER FOUR — TWO VERSIONS OF THE SAME LIFE

The preliminary reports arrived the following morning. The system described them as confidential and instructed each partner not to share the contents until the assisted confrontation. Tomás read that instruction as a challenge. Leonor read it as permission to be alone.

Her report called the relationship stable, functional, and emotionally insufficient. It identified her predominant need as recognition beyond the functions she performed and listed a series of “silent ruptures”: the loss of intimacy after Martim’s birth, the rejected London exchange, the gradual reduction of direct requests for affection, and, in the final year, a transfer of emotional expectation outside the relationship.

Leonor closed the report at that phrase. The system did not need access to her messages to identify Vasco. It had calendars, location patterns, questionnaires she barely remembered completing, and the simplest evidence of all: she had stopped expecting Tomás to ask certain questions and begun hoping Vasco would.

Tomás’s report called the relationship stable and affectively undercommunicated. His predominant mode of love was structural maintenance; his unmet need was recognition for sacrifice. The system described his central pattern as “control through competence.” He reread the words until they stopped sounding like bureaucratic nonsense and began to sound like a diagnosis he had written himself.

At lunch, Martim announced that his class presentation would be about families. “We have to explain what keeps something working,” he said.

“Choose planets,” Tomás suggested.

“Everyone chooses planets.”

“Dinosaurs.”

“Vicente has dinosaurs.” Martim looked at his parents. “Families are more complicated, so mine will be better.”

Leonor gave him the blue bowl. “That is a questionable theory of education.”

Their phones vibrated together. The system had detected a significant external rupture and moved their assisted confrontation forward, requiring them to attend within seventy-two hours.

Martim watched them read. “Is it the button?”

Tomás placed his phone facedown. “It’s a meeting.”

“About us?”

“About the relationship,” Leonor said.

“I’m in the relationship.”

Neither parent corrected him.

The Center for Relational Continuity occupied a glass municipal building near the river. Its waiting room contained no television and no magazines, only chairs arranged far enough apart to preserve the fiction of privacy. A young couple held hands near the window. An older woman sat beside a man who cried without making a sound.

Their facilitator was named Helena. She explained that each partner would make three statements while the other listened without interruption: the relationship they believed they had lived, the person they had become inside it, and what they feared losing if it ended.

Tomás began by saying he believed they had lived a good relationship. Leonor felt her body tighten, but the rules forced her to wait. He described stability, parenthood, problems survived, bills paid, illnesses managed, and the quiet conviction that love had matured rather than disappeared. Only when the system displayed the divergence—Tomás had rated the relationship good or very good in eighty-two percent of annual reports; Leonor had described it as emotionally satisfying in thirty-six percent—did he look as if the floor had shifted beneath him.

“I thought she knew she was loved,” he said. “I never seriously considered leaving. To me, that was proof.”

He admitted that when Leonor spoke of loneliness, he heard an accusation against his effort. Instead of asking what was missing, he defended what he already provided. He had tried to become necessary and had failed to notice that she wanted to feel desired.

When Leonor’s turn came, she said she had lived in a relationship where nothing was wrong enough to justify how lonely she felt. Tomás was faithful, responsible, kind, and present. His goodness made her dissatisfaction feel like ingratitude. She stopped asking because every request seemed to become a trial of his character. Then she began setting tests he did not know he was taking.

She told the truth about Vasco. There had been no kiss and no declared relationship, but there had been concealment, anticipation, and intimacy redirected away from home. “I liked being interesting to someone who didn’t know all the reasons I was tired,” she said. “That doesn’t make what I did innocent.”

The second statements were harder. Tomás had become reliable and unreachable. Leonor had become perceptive and indirect. He managed fear by solving. She managed disappointment by withholding the instructions and judging the result. Neither description allowed one person to remain entirely right.

For the final statement, Leonor said she feared losing the only witness to all her former selves. She feared events would happen and her first instinct would still be to tell Tomás, but she would no longer possess that right. She feared missing half of Martim’s ordinary life. She also feared staying and teaching their son that love meant living permanently with an unnamed absence.

Tomás said he feared everything becoming plural: two homes, two calendars, two sets of keys, two versions of their child’s week. He feared another man entering not only Leonor’s life but Martim’s. Then, after a silence long enough to cost him something, he admitted he feared relief.

“Part of me is tired too,” he said. “I don’t know whether I’m fighting for Leonor, for our family, or for the version of myself who knows how to be useful here.”

The system’s preliminary conclusion did not recommend automatic renewal. It identified persistent affection and mutual responsibility but advised Deep Renegotiation, Structured Separation, or Family Unit.

Outside the building, Leonor stopped beside the car. “You were more honest in there than you’ve been with me in years.”

“So were you.”

“That’s not flattering.”

“No.”

He unlocked the car but did not open the door. “Do you really fear teaching Martim to stay?”

“Do you really fear feeling relieved?”

They stood on opposite sides of the roof, unable to answer without repeating what had already been said. For once, repetition could not make the truth smaller.

CHAPTER FIVE — THE TERMS

Deep Renegotiation required two lists. The first contained what each person needed in order to remain. The second contained what each was personally willing to change without making change conditional on the other.

Tomás disliked the second list immediately. He was practiced at identifying faults in systems and proposing repairs. A form that confined him to his own behavior seemed badly designed.

In the bedroom, he typed that he needed emotional loyalty, not merely physical fidelity. He needed to know that when something mattered, Leonor would bring it to him before taking it elsewhere. He needed permission to be frightened or uncertain without becoming, in her eyes, less dependable. He needed the relationship to stop feeling like an examination whose criteria changed whenever he learned the answers.

Under personal changes, he promised to disclose resentment before converting it into distance. He would stop making family decisions alone and calling the result protection. He would ask a second question when “I’m fine” contradicted everything else in the room, but he would no longer accept responsibility for needs Leonor refused to name.

In the living room, Leonor wrote that she needed curiosity. She wanted Tomás to remain interested in who she was becoming instead of treating ten years of knowledge as a completed file. She needed affection that did not arrive only under threat. She needed room for professional ambition, solitude, and desire without each one being interpreted as an attempt to leave.

Her personal commitments were more difficult. She would state needs before turning them into evidence. She would stop blaming Tomás for decisions she made through fear. She would rebuild an identity that did not depend on being wanted by her husband or noticed by another man. She would not seek elsewhere what she had not first had the courage to ask for at home.

The final question asked what each was no longer willing to sacrifice.

Leonor wrote that she would not reduce her life to preserve the appearance of peace. Tomás wrote that he would not confuse love with being indispensable. Both wrote, in different language, that they would not stay solely for Martim.

When the forms were submitted, the system calculated sixty-four percent compatibility. Most conditions could coexist. One could not.

Leonor required genuine freedom to change, even if change threatened the current shape of the family. Tomás required enough stability to believe the relationship would not be reopened each time one of them glimpsed another possible life.

The system recommended a six-month Structured Separation.

“It thinks your freedom and my security are mutually limiting,” Tomás said.

They sat beside each other on the sofa. Martim was in his room, building a solar system from painted foam balls.

“They are,” Leonor replied.

“You say that very calmly.”

“I’m not calm.” She folded her hands to keep him from seeing them shake. “I’m trying not to promise something I cannot give just because you are afraid.”

“I am afraid.”

"I know."

"You used to try to make that go away."

"I can hold you. I can't make the future certain."

Tomás looked toward the hallway. "And if we separate, do you want the freedom to see Vasco?"

"I don't know."

"That answer is becoming a profession."

"It is still the truth."

The rules allowed outside relationships unless the couple agreed otherwise. Tomás wanted emotional and physical exclusivity during the separation. Leonor argued that feelings could not be regulated and that a separation designed to reveal the truth should not be structured to guarantee one outcome.

"So you want to compare lives," he said.

"Maybe I need to know I came back because I chose you, not because the world stayed closed."

"And I need to know our relationship isn't an open competition."

They negotiated until the language became less useful than the fear beneath it. In the end, they agreed to physical exclusivity and honest disclosure of any emotional connection that began to matter. Neither considered the compromise safe. That was probably why it was honest.

Martim heard enough to understand. He entered the living room carrying Saturn, its cardboard ring bent on one side. "Are you going to live in different houses?"

Leonor moved closer to him. "For six months."

"Then you come back?"

"Then we decide."

"Decide what?"

Tomás answered because Leonor could not. "Whether we can be happier together or whether we are better at being your parents from different homes."

Martim's face changed in the quiet way children's faces do when they understand enough to be frightened but not enough to defend themselves. "I don't want to be better in two homes."

"This isn't your choice to fix," Tomás said.

"That's unfair. I have to live in it."

He carried Saturn back to his room and closed the door.

The system gave Tomás and Leonor seven days to begin. They spent the first evening making a calendar and the second looking at apartments. By the third, Martim had stopped asking whether they might refuse.

CHAPTER SIX — THE HOUSE OF WHAT COMES AFTER

Before Tomás signed the lease, Inês invited them to dinner at the house she had once shared with Rui. They had ended their relationship two years earlier and were now selling the property. The rooms were lined with boxes; pale rectangles marked the walls where photographs had hung.

Inês and Rui moved around the kitchen with the residual coordination of people whose bodies still remembered a shared life. She passed him salt before he asked. He filled her wineglass only halfway. Their tenderness made the sale more difficult to understand.

“We still love each other,” Inês said when Tomás finally asked.

Rui gave her a tired smile. “Not in the way that allows us to build the same life.”

Inês had wanted another city, less work, and a future unorganized by safety. Rui had wanted the house, the familiar neighborhood, and the life they had already made. They had tried therapy, separate bedrooms, travel, and three months apart.

“Every compromise required one of us to pretend we weren’t losing,” Inês said.

“I could have gone with her,” Rui added. “I wanted her. I didn’t want the life she wanted.”

Leonor asked whether Inês was happier.

“I’m more myself.”

“That isn’t the same answer.”

“It is the only one I trust.”

After dinner, Inês took Leonor upstairs to collect the last of her clothes. A single sweater remained in the otherwise empty half of the wardrobe.

“Do you regret it?” Leonor asked.

“Every day, in some form.”

Leonor stared at her. “Then how do you know it was right?”

“I don’t. A right decision can still cost you things you love.” Inês folded the sweater into a box. “For months I thought pain proved I had made a mistake. It only proved I had lost something.”

Downstairs, Rui told Tomás he had spent the first year waiting for Inês to return. He had prepared romantic speeches and cruel ones. Eventually he stopped arranging her side of the bed.

Rui looked toward the dining room, where a pale rectangle remained on the wall after the removal of a bookcase. “I kept looking for the version where nobody suffered. All that did was keep us in the house longer.”

They witnessed the sale documents at eleven twenty. Inês signed last. Afterward, she hugged Rui and cried against his shoulder. He closed his eyes and held her with the expertise of a husband, though he no longer was one.

In the car, Leonor said they should accept the separation.

Tomás did not argue. His agreement frightened her more than resistance would have.

“You could tell me not to go,” she said.

“Then you would spend years wondering whether I trapped you.”

“Maybe I want you to fight.”

“And maybe I’m done proving love by preventing you from doing what you say you need.”

At home, they told Martim together. He asked which of them was leaving. Tomás said he would take the apartment because Martim’s school, room, and routines were anchored where they were.

“So Dad loses the house,” Martim said.

“Dad rents another place,” Tomás corrected.

“That sounds like losing with paperwork.”

On the final night, Martim slept between them. Tomás remained awake, listening to his son breathe and feeling Leonor’s hand beneath his on the mattress. They had shared a bed through illness, pregnancy, money problems, funerals, and years so ordinary they had seemed indestructible. Now a government-approved separation could be measured in the distance between two alarm clocks.

In the morning, Tomás packed two suitcases. Leonor had expected boxes. The smallness of his departure made it look temporary, which was either merciful or dishonest.

At the door, she asked whether he had his medication.

“Yes.”

“The charger?”

“Yes.”

“The blue folder with the apartment documents?”

Tomás smiled faintly. “Leonor.”

“I know.”

They stood without deciding how to say goodbye. A kiss was too intimate, a handshake absurd. She touched his sleeve where a thread had come loose.

“Call if you need anything.”

“You too.”

He carried the suitcases downstairs. Leonor listened until the building door closed. When she returned to the kitchen, his coffee cup remained beside the sink. She washed it, dried it, and put it in the cupboard with the others.

Only then did the house look as though someone had left.

CHAPTER SEVEN — OTHER LIVES

The first month was organized around Martim. Messages between Tomás and Leonor became precise: homework, inhaler, football practice, pickup times, forgotten shoes. Their communication was so efficient that separation initially resembled the marriage they had left, except now the silences happened in different buildings.

Tomás's apartment overlooked the back of another apartment. At night, he could see strangers prepare dinner, water plants, and carry laundry from room to room. He bought four plates, two mugs, and a plant he nearly killed within a week. When Martim visited, toys appeared on the floor and the place briefly acquired a history.

Leonor expected freedom to feel larger. Instead, it first felt like extra space in the wardrobe and nobody asking whether they were out of coffee. She painted again, badly at first. Color returned before confidence did.

At school, Martim drew two houses for an assignment titled *My Home*. His teacher asked which one was the real one.

"Both," he said, then erased the answer and wrote, "I'm still deciding."

Tomás saw the drawing at a parent meeting. The teacher told him Martim was adjusting but trying too hard to protect both parents from his sadness. That night, Tomás called Leonor for a reason unrelated to scheduling.

"He thinks he has to be all right for us."

"I know," she said. "I think we taught him by example."

The call lasted forty minutes. They spoke about their son, then work, then nothing consequential. It was the closest they had felt since the move.

In the second month, Vasco asked Leonor to dinner. The invitation was simple and no longer forbidden. Freedom removed the thrill of secrecy and left only the choice.

She met him at a café near the hospital instead. Vasco said he liked her and did not want their connection rewritten as mere loneliness. Leonor told him it had been real.

"But?" he asked.

"But I used you to hear a version of myself I had stopped hearing at home."

"Does that make me less real?"

"No. It makes me responsible."

She declined dinner. Not for Tomás, she explained, but because she refused to make another person the experiment through which she discovered whether she could live alone.

Vasco left without a dramatic farewell. Leonor watched him cross the street and felt grief without regret.

She told Tomás that night. He thanked her, then admitted the news still hurt. The admission did not become an accusation. They were learning that honesty did not always comfort; sometimes its purpose was simply to prevent a second reality from growing in secret.

In the third month, Beatriz invited Tomás for a drink after work. She and Daniel had ended their relationship shortly after their first review questionnaire exposed a disagreement neither had managed to laugh away: he wanted children and she did not. Their eight months of easy affection had been real;

they had simply been pointing toward different lives. She knew Tomás was separated and asked whether it was an interval or an ending.

“Officially, an interval.”

“And otherwise?”

“I don’t know.”

“That may be the first honest thing anyone has said about a separation.”

He accepted. They spoke for two hours. Outside the bar, Beatriz moved close enough for both of them to understand what might happen. Tomás told her about the physical exclusivity agreement.

“And emotionally?” she asked.

“That’s what I’m trying to find out.”

She stepped back without embarrassment. “Then find out.”

Tomás told Leonor the following morning that he had wanted to kiss Beatriz.

“But you didn’t.”

“No.”

“Because of the agreement?”

“Partly.”

“And the other part?”

Tomás looked through the apartment window at his struggling plant. “I didn’t want my first honest decision after leaving you to be made because someone new found me interesting.”

Leonor was quiet. “I hate that she finds you interesting.”

“I hated Vasco for the same reason.”

“We are not as mature as the forms suggest.”

“That’s a relief.”

They laughed, and the laughter hurt less than either expected.

By the fourth month, the separation had become a life rather than an emergency. Tomás could spend an evening alone without manufacturing a task. Leonor could enjoy the quiet without treating that pleasure as a verdict. Martim still disliked changing houses, but he had stopped packing as if each move might be permanent.

By the fifth month, Martim had stopped counting nights. He had two toothbrushes, two favorite mugs, and a room in Tomás’s apartment decorated with planets. When Leonor asked whether he wanted them to live together again, he considered the question with unsettling care.

“I want one house,” he said. “But I want you to keep talking normally.”

“We can do both.”

“Can you?”

Leonor did not promise.

When the six-month notice arrived, neither could use survival as the reason to return.

CHAPTER EIGHT — WHAT WE MEAN BY STAYING

The final review began with data. Conflict had fallen by seventy-three percent. Individual autonomy had increased by eighty-four. Parental stability was rated acceptable, though Martim's reports contained what the system called "persistent reunification hope." Neither Tomás nor Leonor liked seeing their son translated into a phrase.

They were required to complete one final conversation without a facilitator. The system provided a room, two chairs, water, and no questions. When the door closed, they sat facing one another like people meeting after a long journey from cities that happened to share a name.

Tomás asked if Leonor had been happy without him.

"Sometimes," she said. "You?"

"Sometimes."

Six months earlier, the answers would have sounded like betrayal. Now they sounded like information.

Leonor had been accepted into a six-month professional exchange in London. She had applied without consulting Tomás, not to exclude him but to discover whether she could make a decision before constructing his reaction.

"Do you want it?" he asked.

"Very much."

He felt the old calculations begin: school pickups, hospital shifts, cost, fatigue, the disorder of weeks divided between cities. He did not suppress them; practical consequences mattered. He simply refused to let them become his first and final language.

"I'm afraid London will lead you toward a life where I don't fit," he said.

Leonor's eyes filled, though she did not cry. "Thank you."

"That was not permission."

"I know. It was the truth."

"We would have to redesign the schedule."

"We would."

"And I don't want you to decline and invoice me emotionally in four years."

She laughed. "That seems fair."

Tomás had news too. The firm in Dubai had contacted him again, this time with a consulting arrangement that required travel but not relocation. He had not accepted or declined.

"Do you want it?" Leonor asked.

"Parts of it."

"That is an annoyingly adult answer."

"I've had six months with no one interrupting my development."

The humor passed, leaving the real question. Could they return without making the family the place where ambition came to be buried? Could they preserve autonomy without treating every individual desire as more authentic than shared obligation?

"I don't want the old relationship," Leonor said. "I loved parts of it. I don't want to live inside it again."

"Neither do I."

"Then what does staying mean?"

Tomás considered the word. "It means we continue the conversation before the crisis makes it urgent. It means London is our logistical problem, not your private guilt. Dubai is ours too. It means I don't get permanent security, and you don't get freedom without consequence."

Leonor looked at him. "That doesn't sound romantic."

"I made pancakes. Look what happened."

She laughed, then reached for the water. "It sounds possible."

They did not agree to move back together. They agreed to date for three months while maintaining separate homes. One dinner a week without Martim. One practical meeting about family and money. Therapy twice a month. No using sex to substitute for a decision and no treating physical distance as proof of emotional failure.

When the system asked whether the conversation was complete, they selected no twice. The third time, Leonor chose yes.

"You're sure?" Tomás asked.

"No. I'm finished."

"There's a difference."

"We're becoming experts in them."

Outside, they walked toward the river. Tomás bought two coffees from a kiosk. Leonor took hers, tasted it, and added sugar.

"You stopped taking it without sugar?" he asked.

"About four months ago."

Tomás stared at the packet in her hand.

"Don't look devastated."

"I built part of my identity around knowing your coffee."

"You'll have to meet me again."

He smiled. "Apparently."

CHAPTER NINE — THREE DECISIONS

Miguel and Sara had renewed months earlier, while Tomás and Leonor were still learning how to move Martim between two homes. By the time they invited their friends back to the apartment where Miguel had once worn the apron, the emergency had faded and ordinary life had begun testing every promise he had made.

He cooked again. This time the risotto was worse.

“That seems promising,” Tomás said quietly.

Sara heard him and laughed. “He has become authentically mediocre.”

The campaign had not vanished after renewal, but it had become smaller and less spectacular. Miguel still attended therapy. He also forgot a session and spent one entire Sunday watching football while laundry accumulated. Sara no longer interpreted every lapse as proof that the change had been false.

“Fear woke him,” she told Leonor on the balcony. “That doesn’t mean fear can keep him awake forever. We needed habits after the emergency.”

“Do you trust him?”

“More than I did. Less than he wants.” Sara drank her wine. “Renewal didn’t solve us. It removed his belief that I would always stay regardless of how we lived.”

Inês and Rui represented the opposite decision. Their house had been sold. Rui lived in a smaller apartment near the school; Inês had moved to Évora. They still called each other on birthdays and occasionally reached for the same private joke before remembering it no longer had a home.

Neither regretted ending enough to return. Neither was free of grief. Their example had taught Tomás and Leonor that consequences were not verdicts. Pain did not prove a decision wrong, just as comfort did not prove staying right.

The third decision belonged to them, and its least glamorous consequence was money. Maintaining two apartments while rebuilding a relationship was expensive. They sat with bank statements at Leonor’s kitchen table and learned that romance, in middle age, sometimes required a spreadsheet.

Tomás proposed moving back to reduce costs. Leonor refused.

“We promised three months.”

“We are spending enough to fund Martim’s future university.”

“He can become a plumber.”

“You say that as if plumbers are inexpensive.”

The disagreement sharpened. Tomás accused her of turning caution into principle. Leonor accused him of using numbers to force emotional timing. They raised their voices, stopped, and then did something unfamiliar: they took a break without threatening the relationship.

When they returned to the table, Tomás admitted that the cost frightened him because it made the experiment feel irresponsible. Leonor admitted that moving back frightened her because she did not trust ordinary life not to absorb them again.

They found a compromise. Tomás would give notice on his apartment after two months, but they would preserve a room in the family home as a personal studio, alternating its use according to a schedule neither pretended was romantic.

Their first dates were awkward. At dinner, they almost spoke exclusively about Martim. At the cinema, Leonor fell asleep. During a walk in Alfama, Tomás tried to hold her hand and accidentally caught the strap of her bag.

“Very smooth,” she said.

“I have been out of practice.”

“You have known me for ten years.”

“I’m still adjusting to the sugar. Next you’ll tell me you like mornings.”

They kissed outside her building. It was neither like the first kiss nor like the familiar kisses of their old life. It contained knowledge, grief, caution, and the embarrassing awareness that Martim was probably watching from the window.

He was.

At home, their son pretended he had been looking for the moon.

The three-month experiment did not prove they would remain together. It proved they were capable of participating in the same relationship without immediately returning to their assigned roles. Leonor prepared for London. Tomás accepted the Dubai consultancy. They missed each other and occasionally enjoyed the absence. Neither treated that pleasure as evidence against the relationship.

On the night before the final decision, they ate pizza with Martim. He asked whether the system would announce the result on television.

“No,” Tomás said.

“Good. That would be embarrassing.”

Leonor watched her son add too much hot sauce to one slice. “What do you want us to choose?”

Martim looked wary. “You said it wasn’t my job.”

“It isn’t. I’m still curious.”

He thought about it. “I want one home if you can keep talking normally. If you can’t, I want two homes and no whisper-fighting.”

Tomás looked at Leonor. She was watching Martim tear the crust from his pizza, and neither of them tried to improve his answer.

CHAPTER TEN — THE QUESTION

Renewal Day arrived beneath a clear September sky. Tomás and Leonor traveled separately to the Center, not because the rules required it but because each decision had to exist before they entered the same room.

Helena met them in the waiting area. She looked exactly as she had six months earlier, which felt unreasonable after everything that had changed.

"The final choice will be private," she explained. "If the answers are incompatible, the less binding choice prevails. Before voting, you have fifteen minutes together. No recording, no facilitation."

The room contained a wide window, two chairs, and no clock. Tomás sat first. Leonor remained standing for a moment, looking over the river.

"I know I can live without you," she said.

"I know."

She turned. "That used to sound like the end."

"Now?"

"Now it sounds like the only honest place to choose from."

Tomás nodded. He too had learned that dependence could imitate devotion. Without the fear of practical collapse, he could finally ask whether he wanted Leonor rather than merely the structure that contained her.

"If you choose to end," he said, "I won't think the last months were false."

"Neither will I."

"I may think other unpleasant things for a while."

"That seems healthy."

He smiled, then looked at his hands. "I don't want to restore what we had."

"Good."

"You could pretend to consider it before agreeing."

"I considered it for ten years."

The old Tomás might have defended the life they had built. The new one could honor it without requiring its continuation. "What do you want?"

"I want to build a relationship where staying is not assumed and leaving is not used as a weapon. I want London to be a conversation, not a crime. I want you to tell me when you are afraid before fear becomes a spreadsheet."

"Spreadsheets are innocent."

"No one believes that."

"And I want you to tell me what you need before I fail to guess it. I want our life to be stable enough to rest in and flexible enough that neither of us has to vanish."

Leonor sat opposite him. "That sounds difficult."

"It sounds more difficult than divorce on some days."

"Probably."

"Do you still want it?"

She looked at the man she knew better than anyone and who had, over the last months, become unfamiliar in ways she liked. "Yes."

The word did not finish the decision. It simply made it possible.

In separate booths, the screens showed the same five options. Before Tomás could select one, the interface changed. The categories disappeared and a single question occupied the display.

Knowing who this person is, and knowing who you have become, would you choose to begin with them today?

Tomás thought of Dubai, the apartment, Beatriz, Martim's two houses, and the coffee Leonor now sweetened. He thought of the life he could still build without using his family as either an excuse or a reward.

He chose yes.

Leonor thought of London, Vasco, the relief of her quiet home, the cost of returning, and the man who no longer needed to be indispensable. She chose yes.

The screens confirmed compatible answers. They were asked whether they wished to restore the previous relationship or register a new relational agreement.

Both selected new agreement.

When they emerged, Helena handed them a tablet containing an empty terms page. "The state recognizes your decision," she said. "The rest belongs to you."

Tomás looked at Leonor. "Where do we start?"

"With lunch."

"That is not very profound."

"I'm hungry. We can become symbolic afterward."

They left the Center still arguing about lunch. Halfway down the steps, Leonor took his hand. Tomás did not mention it, and she did not let go.

CHAPTER ELEVEN — ORDINARY DAYS

They did not tell Martim they were “back together.” The phrase suggested they had returned to a place. Instead, they told him they had chosen to create one home again and that Tomás would move back after the end of the school term.

“So the experiment worked?” Martim asked.

Tomás considered the question. “It showed us what didn’t work.”

“That sounds like school.”

“Unfortunately, most of life does.”

The move was less emotional than the departure. Tomás had accumulated furniture, books, kitchen equipment, and one recovering plant. Leonor objected to the second coffee machine. Tomás argued that it had supported him through a constitutional crisis. They gave it to Inês.

The studio room became real. Leonor’s paints occupied one wall; Tomás’s drawing table stood by the window. The arrangement was inconvenient when both wanted it, which forced the kind of negotiation they had once postponed until resentment made it ceremonial.

London altered the household. For six months, Tomás handled school, meals, and the invisible decisions he had previously believed occurred by nature, while Leonor learned that independence could be exhilarating and lonely at the same time. The Dubai consultancy placed him on an airplane twice a month. Supporting his ambition, she discovered, did not require enthusiasm about delayed flights.

They continued therapy after the system stopped requiring it. They also failed in ordinary ways. Tomás withdrew during one argument about money. Leonor said “nothing” when something was clearly wrong, then returned ten minutes later and tried again. On a winter evening, they ate dinner in front of separate screens and did not notice until Martim asked whether the old relationship was visiting.

That sentence became family language. Whenever silence changed from restful to evasive, one of them asked whether the old relationship had come by. Sometimes the question annoyed them. It worked anyway.

Three months after Tomás returned, they held a private ceremony on the balcony. There were no officials or guests. Martim wore a button-up shirt over football shorts because only the top half appeared in photographs.

Leonor unfolded the terms they had written together. They included practical commitments about money, work, parenting, solitude, affection, and review. At the bottom, Tomás had added that they would read the agreement together at least once a year. Leonor crossed out *at least once a year* and wrote *whenever one of us asks* above it. Tomás pretended to object, then signed beneath the amendment.

Leonor read the page again and looked at him. “Do you agree to these terms?”

“Most of them.”

“Tomás.”

“Yes.” He took her hands. “I do.”

Martim groaned. “That was obvious.”

Leonor laughed. “And you? Do you choose this?”

Tomás looked at the woman he no longer expected to remain unchanged. “Yes, I do. Again.”

CHAPTER TWELVE — AGAIN

Five years later, the next notice arrived on a Tuesday morning. Tomás found it on the kitchen table beside a bowl of fruit and a mathematics worksheet Martim had abandoned after writing *unreasonable question* across the margin.

Leonor entered carrying two mugs. At forty-two, she had acquired a narrow line between her eyebrows that remained faintly visible even when she laughed. She placed his coffee beside him and looked at the envelope.

“Already?”

“Five years.”

“That seems administratively aggressive.”

Martim came in wearing one sock and a school shirt he had buttoned incorrectly. “What came?”

“Our Renewal notice,” Leonor said.

He glanced at it while taking a piece of toast. “Oh.”

Tomás waited. “That is all?”

“You’ll renew.” Martim reached for another piece. “Can I have this?”

Leonor looked at Tomás. Their son had grown up in the relationship they rebuilt, not the one that had nearly disappeared. To him, Renewal was an appointment his parents attended and then complained about over dinner.

“You can have it if you fix your shirt,” she said.

Their life had not settled into the polished version Tomás once imagined. Leonor completed the London exchange and returned with greater confidence, a dislike of instant coffee, and no desire to move permanently. Tomás ended the Dubai consultancy after two years and founded a small Lisbon studio with two colleagues. It earned less than the partnership might have, demanded more than he had promised, and allowed him to eat dinner at home often enough that Martim noticed when he did not.

They still failed at the agreement in familiar ways. Leonor delayed conversations when she was tired. Tomás hid inside work when he felt ashamed. During the studio’s difficult second year, he used part of their savings without telling her. She spent two weeks speaking to him with a courtesy so exact that even Martim became nervous. They returned to therapy, argued about the same facts in several different orders, and changed how the business accounts were separated from the household accounts. Forgiveness did not make the episode disappear. It stopped it from governing every later disagreement.

Their appointment was scheduled for Thursday afternoon. They left Martim at school, worked through the morning, and met for lunch near the river. Neither had much appetite.

“Do you remember what we ate before the first appointment?” Leonor asked.

“Nothing.”

“Two terrible sandwiches.”

“That supports my answer.”

After lunch they walked beside the Tagus. The air was cool, and ferries left white seams across the water. Tomás asked whether she ever imagined what would have happened if they had ended the relationship five years earlier.

“Sometimes,” she said. “Not often now.”

“What do you imagine?”

"Two apartments. Too many messages about school. Us being very reasonable with each other."

"We would have tried."

"That is what worries me."

He asked whether she regretted returning from London.

"No."

"You answered quickly."

"I was lonely there."

"You never said that."

"I said I missed you."

"That is not the same."

"No," she said. "It wasn't."

At the Renewal Center, Helena met them in the waiting room. Her hair had gone almost entirely gray, and she now wore reading glasses on a thin chain. She remembered London, the studio, and the drawing of the bridge Martim had made before their first Identity Review.

"He is thirteen now," Tomás said.

"That was not the question."

"It explains most things."

Helena took them to the same office they had used before. The furniture had changed, but Tomás remembered how carefully he and Leonor had once avoided touching.

This time Helena asked only what had been most difficult about staying together.

"Protecting time," Leonor said. "There was always something more urgent, and sometimes we used that as permission."

Tomás took longer. "Accepting that a choice can be right and still involve regret. When I wondered about Dubai or resented what the studio cost us, I treated the feeling as disloyalty. Then I hid it, which was worse."

Leonor looked at him but allowed him to finish.

Helena placed two forms before them. Five years earlier, they had needed separate rooms. This time they completed the forms side by side. Tomás read every line; Leonor finished first and waited without watching his pen.

Both chose Renewal.

Helena stamped the forms. The sound was a small mechanical thud.

"That's it?" Tomás asked.

"You will receive confirmation by email."

"I expected something more ceremonial."

Leonor stood. "He wanted a certificate."

Outside, rain had begun. Leonor opened an umbrella she had remembered to bring, and Tomás held it badly enough that one shoulder of her jacket became wet. They stopped for coffee instead of going home; neither felt different, which was less disappointing than Tomás had expected.

They collected Martim from a friend's apartment that evening. He was carrying half a cake in someone else's container.

"Did you renew?" he asked.

"We did," Leonor said.

Martim nodded. "Okay."

Tomás looked offended. "We made an important decision."

"You said you were going to."

"We could have changed our minds."

Martim considered this. "But you didn't."

Epilogue — The Next Question

Six years later, a girl named Beatriz asked Martim whether he believed in the Renewal Program. They were nineteen and waiting for a bus after an afternoon lecture. Her parents' review was due the following month, and she had spent several days pretending not to be afraid.

"Mine renewed twice," Martim said.

"Did you know they would?"

He thought of the first review, which he remembered as a period when both parents had become unnaturally polite. "The second time."

"What happened the first time?"

"They separated for a while."

Beatriz stared at him. "You never told me that."

"You never asked."

The electronic sign above the stop claimed the bus would arrive in four minutes. It had displayed the same estimate for nearly ten.

"Did the Program save them?" she asked.

"No."

"Then what did?"

Martim disliked the word *save*. "They got better at saying things before they became everybody's problem."

"That's all?"

"They still get it wrong."

Beatriz sat on the edge of the bench. "My parents had an argument last night."

"An argument doesn't tell you what they'll choose."

"You don't know that."

"No."

That evening Martim found his parents arguing in the kitchen because Tomás had said he would be home at seven and arrived close to eight. Leonor had kept dinner warm. Tomás had sent a message too late to be useful.

They stopped when Martim entered.

"Should I leave?" he asked.

"No," they said together.

He set three plates on the table while his father explained the meeting that had delayed him. Leonor listened with her arms folded.

"You're explaining," she said when he finished.

Tomás looked at the floor, then at her. "I'm sorry I was late. I should have warned you before the meeting."

Leonor's shoulders lowered slightly. "I don't need you home at exactly seven. I need not to feel foolish for believing you."

"I know."

The fish was dry, but they ate it. Later, while looking for a charger, Martim found the family folder in the living-room cabinet. The two Renewal statements lay inside with the bridge drawing he had made before their first Identity Review.

The towers leaned in opposite directions, and the three people crossing between them had circular heads and enormous hands. Across the top, in uneven letters, he had written, *We go together*.

Tomás appeared behind him. "What are you doing?"

"Looking for a charger."

"In the school records?"

"I got distracted."

Martim slid the page into his chemistry textbook so it would lie flat. From the kitchen came the sound of the dishwasher beginning its cycle and Tomás asking Leonor where she had put his keys.

"In the bowl where they belong," she called.

Martim closed the textbook and went to help him look.